

CHAPTER 26

A GOVERNMENT FALLS, CRACKS SHOW IN SPY CASE

'If the buggers came, I would have shot them—or myself.'

Meena did not cry. Neither did she smile.

It did not take me long to realise that my wife had, ever since my arrest on 30 November 1994, plunged into severe depression. The cry, that animal shriek that no animal could produce, she let out when I returned home from jail on 18 January 1995 had startled me. Now I was told that that was the first time she had made any sound. Her tears were shed in silence.

During my absence, she continued to visit the temples, some times for long hours. Once, much after the Attukal Temple had closed, she remained there, putting the temple managers in a fix. After much persuasion, she allowed a person to drop her home. The only other person she went to was her youngest sister Usha who lived in their ancestral home not too far from our house. Meena would lie on Usha's lap for hours on end, wide awake, without uttering a word.

When my son and relatives visited me in the jail, the rare mention about Meena has been vague, I remembered. I knew she would be feeling terrible after my arrest, but I hoped her faith in God, her daily temple visits, her deep sense of spiritualism would help her sail through the rough seas. But she had sunk.

Not that I was in any better mental shape. Returning home and being with my folks came as a solace, but the uncertainty of my professional and